

## Flight

Birds that can fly have wings and a very light skeleton – many of the bones are hollow. Their short and compact bodies also help make them neat fliers.

There are two methods of flying; flapping, like this red-tailed minla, and gliding.

By flapping its wings up and down, the bird remains in the air.

Red-tailed minla

## Travelling birds

About one-third of birds spend summer in one place then when the winter sets in they fly thousands of miles to a warmer spot. Often they go to exactly the same places year after year.



## Feet

The shapes of birds' feet vary in different habitats.



**Eagle foot:** birds of prey have sharp talons to kill and grip animals.



**Perching foot:** songbirds have three toes in front and one behind for perching.



**Webbed foot:** waterfowl have webbed feet to help them to paddle on water.



**Ostrich foot:** two thick toes help this flightless bird to run very fast.

## Bills

The shape and size of a bird's bill, or beak, show what they eat.



**Duck:** wide and flat to tear plants and filter food underwater.



**Woodpecker:** long and hard to chisel into wood and pick out insects.



**Chaffinch:** short and cone-shaped, ideal for cracking seeds.



**Heron:** ideal for stabbing fish underwater.

## Communication

All birds have good hearing so they can respond to songs from other members of their family. Birds are well known for their tunes, and some, like this parrot, even speak.

